

create a more spiritual idea of worship. There was a truer recognition of the sovereignty of holiness by which alone they could hope for national perfection. However hollow their religion may have been, this recognition was an omen of good.

The Jews came into direct touch with Persia in the Babylonian exile and for more than two hundred years afterward. Cyrus, the Persian king, "the righteous one, the Shepherd of the Lord, the anointed of God,"⁴⁵ gave orders that the temple at Jerusalem be rebuilt and that the Jews be returned from captivity to their own city.⁴⁶ Darius, the worshipper of Ormazd, favored the rebuilding of the temple and commanded that the decree of Cyrus be carried into effect.⁴⁷ Judea became a Persian province and remained so till the time of Alexander. There are probably references to the ancient faith of Persia in Ezekiel and Deutero-Isaiah.⁴⁸ The Wise men who came from the East to worship Christ, were Magi, followers of the ancient creed of Persia, and it is actually stated in the Apocryphal New Testament that they came in accordance with a prophecy of Zarathustra.⁴⁹

The chief characteristics of the Zoroastrian religion in brief are: the philosophic tenet which recog-

45. Isa. XLI:2, XLIV:28, XLV:1-3, 13.

46. II. Chron. XXXVI:22-23, Ezra I:1-17, III:7, IV:3, I Esdras II:1-7.

48. Ezra VI:1-15, I Esdras III:42-57.

48. Ezek. VIII:16, Isa. XLV:7, 12.

49. Infancy III:1 cf. Mt. II:1-2.

nizes the constant warfare that rages between the good principle Ahura Mazda, or Ormazd, (*Ὁρομάσδης*) and the evil spirit, Angro Mainyu, Ahrmian, (*Ἀρεϊμάνιος*), and their respective kingdoms. The duration of this conflict is limited, at the end of the world good will triumph, and evil be annihilated; a general resurrection of the dead will take place and the new life begin. There is also in the religion an elaborate system of angels and demons, a distinct cosmology and cosmogony, a pronounced doctrine of eschatology, and a high code of ethics. There are also elements of nature worship, a deification of sun, moon and stars, a religious veneration for fire, earth, and water, and a scrupulous awe in exercising care to preserve these elements from defilement. These nature features seem to point back to earlier times. In addition there is a rigid dogmatism that inculcates the necessity of preserving the purity of the body, the care of useful animals, the practice of agriculture, and the observance of a strictly defined ritual.

To bring Judaism and Zoroastrianism more clearly into view, the beliefs wherein they agree may be summarized briefly. Each was proclaimed by a prophet. Each worshipped one God. Each believed in an evil power. Each forbade images. Each laid emphasis on a moral act. Each was intolerant toward other systems. Each developed priestly cults, and emphasized ceremonial cleanness. Each had something like a synagogue worship. Belief in

angels and demons and in the future life were ideas common to both.

Surely with so many points of agreement here at once were influences that would tend to unify them. During all these years in which Judaism was gradually assuming form the most intelligent and active members of the Jewish race were brought into continued contact with the dominant peoples of the age.⁵⁰ Since in other respects their habits were changed by the new environment, it would have been strange indeed if their religion had been unaffected. The Babylonians were too gross in their idolatry to develop Jewish religious conceptions. But the Jews were attracted by the faith that had so many articles in accord with their own teachings.

The policy of the Persians towards the Jews also would render the Jews favorably disposed toward their rulers.⁵¹ There is evidence, too, that during the Persian period the Jewish community received many foreigners into its midst.⁵² The influences which tended to keep the two religions apart were, that the Hebrews were so little known, so little in contact with other peoples, and their priesthood so exclusive, that it is not likely they would

50. "Mordecai the Jew was next unto king Ahasuerus, and great among the Jews, and accepted of the multitude of his brethren; seeking the good of his people." Esther X:3; also Esther VII:8, VIII:7-17, Dan. VI:1-3, 14, 28, VIII:3.

51. Isa. XLIV:28, XLV:1-4, II Chron. XXXVI:22-23, Ezra I:1-4, II Macca. I:18-24, 31-35, Ezra VI:1-15.

52. Zech VIII:22-23, Isa. LVI:3-8, "Many of the people of the land became Jews." Esther VIII:17

exert any strong influence upon Persian ideas. The Persians being rulers would have made this influence less likely. On the other hand, the Jewish horror of heathen nations together with their devotion to the covenant, erected that high wall of separation which isolated Judaism during more than four centuries. Further, during a large part of the Persian period, the attitude of the satraps toward the Palestinian Jews would not dispose the latter consciously to imitate. Those in the Dispersion would not consciously have adopted Persian ideas when their hearts said, "How shall we sing the Lord's song in a strange land."⁵³ No important belief of Judaism was adopted outright from the Iranian faith, but without foreign influence some of the leading beliefs would not have been grasped and so fully developed, as they appear to have been from this time. To trace the resemblances between the two religions, and to indicate something of the probable influence of the one upon the other will occupy the remainder of this volume.

53. Psa. CXXXVII:4.